

THE COLLECTIVE MIGHT
Prime Minister Narendra Modi joins other NDA leaders at a rally in Meerut, Uttar Pradesh, Mar. 31

TO COUNTER BJP'S CONSOLIDATION OF THE NON-YADAV OBC AND DALIT VOTES, THE SP HAS COINED PDA, A SOCIAL COALITION OF PICHHDE (OBC), DALIT (SC) AND ALPASANKHYAK (MINORITIES)

says Professor Krishna Hombal, chairman of the political science department at the University of Mysore. "Most Opposition leaders don't have a performance record to showcase." I.N.D.I.A. itself is perceived to be a ragtag coalition of parties who do not even trust each other very much, let alone exuding a promise of stable governance. "All the issues raised by the Opposition parties have resonance on the ground. But do the voters trust the Opposition parties to make the difference? That's the key question," says Zaad Mahmood, associate professor at Presidency University in Kolkata.

What the Opposition alliance also lacks is a single leader who can be a magnet for the masses and challenge the popularity of the prime minister, particularly in forming the central government. "Narendra Modi has changed the grammar of Indian politics," says Prof. Sangit Kumar Ragi, head of the department of political science at Delhi University. "In the Lok Sabha polls, where it's a direct contest with him, the Opposition parties are yet to counter him in his own language. Often, they have come across as poor copies."

Rahul Gandhi, as leader of the largest Opposition party, ends up by default as the prime minister's chief rival. And the gap in their popularity remains massive—55 per cent of the respondents in the INDIA TODAY Mood of the Nation poll in February 2024 wanted Modi as the next PM compared to 15 per cent for Rahul. The fact that he is often missing in action or makes unintended gaffes undoes his personal aura of sincerity. A fortnight before the election is to begin, the Gandhi siblings have yet to signal their intent on contesting from Amethi or Rae Bareli as mother Sonia chooses to take the Rajya Sabha route. In his defence, his aides say Rahul's vision is for the long term. "He wants to shape an ideological battle for the future. Once the people understand his message, the churn will come automatically," says an aide.

Others hope that, as in 2004, when there was no clear Opposition leader to challenge Prime Minister A.B. Vajpayee and nothing to counter the BJP's India Shining narrative, the tide turns again. Professor Narayana Sukumar of Delhi University believes that a face does not determine the outcome of a clash of ideologies. "The contest has to be seen as a battle between two ideologies and the voters will decide which side wins. The leader will emerge," he says.

And while the BJP seems unassailable given its leader's undiminished popularity, its potent mix of Hindutva and nationalism and the Union government's development record, the controversy over electoral bonds, the alleged unleashing of central agencies against Opposition leaders and their arrests, and the open splitting of parties and poaching of their leaders are creating a sense of unease. But beyond the fear-mongering over the death of democracy, the Opposition parties need to convince the voters that they have the solutions to tackle the issues they have been raising against the BJP—of economic and social injustice. How well they do it will determine the outcome of the 2024 election. ■

-with inputs from Amitabh Srivastava